

PLANTING

Seedlings that have been started indoors, whether in multi-packs or individual planting pots, will be ready to plant out when they have grown four or five mature leaves. Keep them moist and lift them out carefully, trying not to disturb the roots too much, since this can damage later growth.

Plant into a moist bed of soil and provide seedlings with temporary shade to help prevent wilting. If the weather turns cold, or you are worried about pests and diseases, protect vulnerable seedlings with a cloche or cold frame.

CROP CARE

Once lettuces have been planted out, keep them free from weeds and well-watered at all times.



Harvest as cut-and-come-again crops.

This is especially important in the one or two weeks before harvesting, because too much heat or a lack of water can cause the lettuces to bolt. It can also cause them to become bitter.

Most lettuces will not need any extra fertilization, but if growth seems slow, feed them with a nitrogenous fertilizer.

TIP PREVENTING A GLUT

Lettuce can be grown in every season with managed planting, especially if you can provide winter protection. Plant carefully to avoid gluts, because lettuce doesn't keep well once picked. To ensure a steady harvest, sow seeds frequently and in small batches—a handful of seeds every few weeks. Intercrop lettuces to harvest as early season “catch crops” to maximize space.



Seed sown in batches will provide you with a continual supply of lettuce.